SMOKED SALMON–BLACK WALNUT SPREAD

makes about 3 cups

In this riff on a creamy fish spread, smoky salmon is bound together with a rich black walnut cream and made aromatic with herbs and capers. Northern California has its own species of black walnut, *Juglans hindsii*. You can also find eastern black walnut trees growing sporadically throughout the region as well.

If you don't have home-smoked salmon on hand, you can also make this with store-bought hot-smoked salmon.

- 8 ounces shelled black walnuts
- 2 tablespoons agave syrup
- 8 ounces Hot-Smoked Salmon (page 281), flaked
- ¼ cup finely chopped wild onion greens or chives
- ¼ cup Dandelion or Milkweed Capers (page 38), finely chopped
- 2 tablespoons finely chopped fennel fronds, plus a few sprigs for garnish
- Sea salt
- Cassava chips, for serving

In a saucepan, combine 2 cups water, the black walnuts, and agave syrup and bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low and simmer for 5 minutes to soften the nuts. Turn off the heat and let cool to warm.

Transfer to a high-powered blender and puree to form a thick cream. Scrape it into a bowl and cool to room temperature.

Fold in the salmon, wild onion greens, dandelion capers, and fennel fronds. Taste and season with salt as needed.

Cover and refrigerate until well chilled, then serve with cassava chips and a few extra fennel fronds on top for garnish.

DANDELION OR MILKWEED CAPERS

makes about 1 cup

When harvested while they're tightly closed and green, dandelion and milkweed buds make excellent capers. (You can also make capers out of nasturtium buds if you have them growing in your garden.)

Dandelion buds first appear in large numbers in early spring. You might also find them during other parts of the season. The best dandelion buds for capers are those that are tightly closed and growing close to the ground. Skip any of the buds attached to stems, or any that, when squeezed, reveal the yellow flower within. To find these buds, you sometimes need to push apart the leaves. If you like, you can also dig out the dandelion plant and find some buds growing just below the surface of the ground, waiting for their time in the sun. You can use the leaves for salads or pestos and roast the roots for tea.

You'll generally see milkweed buds in late spring or early summer growing in clusters. Harvest some of the clusters (but leave some on the plant, too!) and separate the individual buds before pickling.

- ¾ cup dandelion or milkweed buds
- ½ cup cider vinegar
- 2 teaspoons fine sea salt

If your dandelion buds have a visible calyx attached (the leaves that fan out from the bottom of the bud), remove it. Put your buds in a bowl of water and swish them around to dislodge any grit or debris. Lift them out of the water to drain.

Bring a medium pot of water to a boil. Add the buds and blanch for about 30 seconds, until bright green. Drain and shake dry, then transfer to a 1-pint jar.

In another pot, combine the vinegar, salt, and ½ cup water and bring to a simmer over medium heat, stirring to dissolve the salt. Pour this hot brine over the buds and let stand until cooled to room temperature.

Seal and refrigerate. Ideally, you'll want to let the buds pickle for at least 1 week before using the capers. Refrigerate for up to 2 months.

Note: *These capers are designed to be refrigerator pickles that you keep for a couple of months. If you prefer to make pickles for long-term storage, you can process the jars in a water bath.*